

punishment for his terrible deeds. The roots of the Tree of Life that hold the underworld form a maze so complicated that no beast has ever escaped. Tell Nidhogg to accept his punishment.”

“He is a monster, not a God.”

The squirrel trembled in terror at the thought of telling Nidhogg this message. Instead, he fled to the seventh world, where he had stored his nuts in a den, ready for a long winter. Nidhogg slid back and forth along the huge roots, waiting for the squirrel to return. His anger grew, and he roared into the worlds above.

“If I do not receive word from the Gods that I am to be freed, I will begin to chew upon the Tree of Life this very evening!”

But the Gods were too far away, and the squirrel was nestled in his bed of nuts with leaves stuffed into his ears. Nobody heard Nidhogg’s warning. That very night, Nidhogg opened his huge jaws and clamped his ferocious fangs down on the roots. The tree writhed in pain and the worlds were flung from side to side. Mountains crumbled and oceans spun.

By morning, Nidhogg had gnawed through the root and the tree began to wilt and split in two.

Light crept into the roots below and lit up the darkness. Nidhogg raised his head and slithered up the tree.

The Gods threw their powers at the raging dragon, causing hail, lightning, comets, and lava to rain down upon him. They tossed mountains at him like arrows, and rerouted rivers to try to wash him away. But the Gods were no match for Nidhogg’s anger. A war raged for a century until finally the Gods grew weak. Nidhogg sneered as he froze each of them in turn, and spread winter across the worlds.

Laughing as the final world froze over, Nidhogg smiled at the icy Gods, powerless against him.

The branches of the Tree of Life weakened their hold around the worlds and withered. One by one, the nine worlds tumbled out into the universe, and Nidhogg was left alone again, with nothing to rule, roaming the night skies in silence in search of the very things he had destroyed.